

World in Brief: Death toll from Colombian quake rises; Nvidia looks to raise \$500bn



Photograph: Getty Images

Colombia declared a state of emergency after an **earthquake** killed over 200 people. The epicentre of the 7.4-magnitude quake was in the western Chocó province, in the country's coffee-growing region. It toppled buildings across the province, trapping many under the rubble. The cities of Cali, Pereira and Manizales were all affected. Officials warned the death toll is likely to rise.

Nvidia said it had approached six of the biggest names in finance—Apollo, Blackstone, BlackRock, Brookfield, Goldman Sachs and KKR—to help it raise \$500bn to spend on AI infrastructure. Details are scant, but Jensen Huang, the chipmaker's boss, said none had turned it down. Investors, who are already worried about how much AI-related firms are spending, balked. Nvidia's shares closed almost 3% down yesterday.

The **Houthis** attacked a cargo ship in the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, killing four crew members—the first deaths from a Houthi strike since the Iran war began. Last month the Yemeni rebels launched a naval [blockade against Saudi Arabia](#), hitting Saudi-linked tankers in the Red Sea and oil facilities. But the struck vessel was not Saudi-owned; the Iran-aligned group has not yet claimed the attack.

A court in Syria sentenced **Bashar al-Assad**, the country's former president, to death in absentia for committing "crimes against humanity" during Syria's bloody civil war. Mr Assad fled to Russia after his regime was toppled in 2024. Atef Najib, Mr Assad's cousin and a high-ranking general under the Assad regime, was also sentenced to death. Over 500,000 people died in the conflict.

Donald Trump dismissed **Iran's** demand for compensation for damage caused by the war. In fact, he posted, Iran should pay for the "damages and death" it has caused across the Middle East, including in Lebanon and Gaza, where he said it had promoted conflicts and detonated "roadside bombs". Earlier Iran said it would not open the [Strait of Hormuz](#) until America ended its blockade of Iranian ports.

Taiwan slowed its mobile internet services across more than a dozen cities and counties, simulating disruption that might follow a Chinese attack. Accompanied by air-raid drills which cleared the streets, this was the first time such a test has been included in the self-governing island's annual war games. It will be repeated on Thursday in other cities including the capital, Taipei.

America's president hid in a **catering container** in order to board a secret military flight from Turkey to Britain last month, according to new reports. Mr Trump departed [a NATO summit](#) in Ankara following an Iranian assassination threat. After boarding Air Force One in front of television cameras, he was smuggled onto a second plane via a cart used to transport in-flight meals.

Figure of the day: 2.25bn, the number of cups of coffee drunk across the world each day. But [climate change is putting your morning brew at risk](#).

The US in Brief: Trump attacks childhood vaccination



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump signed an executive order that calls for changes to federal recommendations for administering **vaccinations to children**. It proposes fewer immunisation shots and splitting the measles, mumps and rubella vaccine into three separate jabs. Mr Trump falsely linked rising vaccine rates to cases of autism in children. The order was criticised by the American Academy of Paediatrics, which called Mr Trump's claims "misleading".

Two Republican senators leading an investigation into **Anthony Fauci's** response to the covid-19 pandemic released some of his text messages from 2021, when he was chief medical adviser. They mostly relate to taking the vaccine during pregnancy. Dr Fauci wrote that while data on the jab was scant and there were theoretical hazards, covid-19 was known to be dangerous in pregnancy, so "one must weigh the potential risks against the benefits."

The **Food and Drug Administration** proposed a rule requiring manufacturers to disclose new additives they plan to use in food and drinks, along with evidence of their safety. This would close a [loophole](#) that has for decades allowed companies to add ingredients without government oversight. The FDA also said it submitted for

final review a federal definition of [ultra-processed foods](#), although this was not released.

A state judge in New York blocked, for now, the implementation of a **pied-à-terre tax** on worth \$5m or more. Homeowners recently sued the city and Zohran Mamdani, its mayor, partly alleging “confusion and unwanted public scrutiny” after a list of nearly 1m addresses potentially subject to the tax was made public. The mayor’s office said it would appeal against the decision.

Todd Blanche was sworn in as attorney-general. The Senate narrowly approved his confirmation on Saturday after two Republican holdouts were assured by Mr Blanche, a former personal lawyer for Mr Trump, that he would not create a \$1.8bn “anti-weaponisation fund” to compensate the president’s MAGA allies. Some Senate Republicans have expressed worries about the Department of Justice’s independence under Mr Trump.

An appeals court in San Francisco allowed more than 3,000 **social-media addiction lawsuits** against platforms including Meta, Google, ByteDance and Snap to proceed. The companies had argued for immunity under Section 230, which shields online platforms from liability for third-party content. But the court said their appeal was filed too early.

The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration said July was the **hottest month** on record for the contiguous United States, with an average temperature just shy of 76.9°F (25°C), more than three degrees Fahrenheit above the 20th-century average. Extreme heat, which scientists have said is exacerbated by climate change, disrupted events across the country, including 4th of July celebrations in Washington, DC. It has also caused drought and fuelled wildfires.

Another test for the Democratic left



Photograph: Getty Images

Wisconsin's Democratic primary for governor takes place on Tuesday. Francesca Hong, a member of the state assembly and a Democratic Socialist, is the clear favourite; her closest challenger is David Crowley, a more centrist politician.

[America's populist left](#) is enjoying a red-letter summer. Last week Abdul El-Sayed, who calls himself a capitalist but draws support from the socialist crowd, won Michigan's Senate primary. Their success is in part thanks to full-throated campaigning. The Democrats' left wing skews young, and combines social-media savvy with a willingness to put boots on the ground.

Midterm elections in November will test whether such left-wingers can win enough centrist and independent voters. Ms Hong's opponents have highlighted her past tweets calling to abolish the police and "cancel Thanksgiving", suggestions she has since disavowed. Moderate Democrats say she could push swing voters into the Republicans' arms. Ms Hong may be a risky bet in an important battleground state.

Colombia's new president responds to disaster



Photograph: AP

Twenty-four hours after a four-minute-long, 7.4-magnitude earthquake shook western and southern Colombia, the scale of the tragedy is becoming clear. The quake has killed at least 160 people, injured more than 500 and damaged 1,575 buildings. Those numbers will rise. For Colombians there is a grim sense of déjà-vû. The earthquake was as strong as the pair that [hit neighbouring Venezuela](#) in June, killing thousands.

Colombia's authorities have acted more quickly than Venezuela's did. Three days into the job of president, [Abelardo de la Espriella](#) has pledged "unwavering determination" to contain the crisis. He declared a national disaster, allowing him to draw from the budget via decree, and dispatched his cabinet to the badly affected cities of Pereira, Cali and Quibdó, where the only hospital is overwhelmed. Soldiers have been deployed to deter looting. In Chocó, the region where the shock originated, victims will get housing aid. The Trump administration, which counts Mr de la Espriella as an ally, has allocated \$15.5m in relief.

Elbit Systems is as controversial as it is profitable

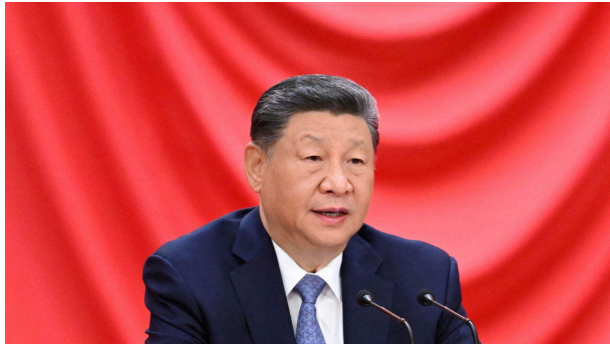


Photograph: Getty Images

Israel's biggest defence firm reported a strong second-quarter on Tuesday, with adjusted earnings up by about 28% compared with a year earlier. Underpinning Elbit Systems' growth is a record order backlog worth more than \$32bn. Roughly two-thirds of Elbit's earnings come from overseas, especially Europe, where there is [strong demand](#) for its electronic-warfare expertise and its command-and-control systems.

But the company's domestic deals have attracted criticism. In supplying Israel's armed forces with most of their land-based and unmanned aerial systems, Elbit has benefited from the high tempo of [operations in Gaza, the West Bank and Lebanon](#). That has made the company a target for human-rights groups and divestment campaigns, with some success. Barclays and HSBC, two big banks, as well as some European pension funds, have reportedly sold their shares in Elbit as a result. A deal announced last month to supply surveillance technology to America's Customs and Border Protection, worth \$370m, has further enraged Elbit's activist opponents.

China's leaders' seaside sojourn



Photograph: Alamy

President Xi Jinping and other Communist Party bigwigs have left behind a sweltering Beijing for a beachside resort in the town of Beidaihe. But they are not lazing about. Officials are sequestered at a secret annual conclave, holding important policy discussions on the economy and China's drive to become a science and technology superpower.

Economic growth unexpectedly slowed in the second quarter, to 4.3% compared with a year earlier, below the government's target of 4.5-5%. China's leaders will probably use their retreat to draft plans for greater fiscal support to boost the economy. The other focus appears to be the government's innovation push. Last week senior scientists and technologists were invited there to brief China's leaders, who are looking for ways to support scientific research, as promised in the government's latest [Five-Year Plan](#).

Orban-renewal in Hungary



Photograph: Getty Images

Hungary's parliament will vote on whether or not to make András Baka, a former head of the Supreme Court, the president on Tuesday. Mr Baka is considered to be a shoo-in; he was nominated by Tisza, the party of [Peter Magyar](#), the prime minister, which has a two-thirds majority in parliament. In 2011 Fidesz, the party of Viktor Orbán (Mr Magyar's predecessor), removed Mr Baka from the Supreme Court on spurious grounds, seemingly because of his criticism of Mr Orbán's illiberal judicial reforms.

Hungary's president plays a largely symbolic role, but in this instance the symbolism is significant. Last month Mr Magyar removed Tamás Sulyok from the presidency through a constitutional amendment because he didn't want an "Orbán puppet", as he put it, in the role. He proposed Judit Polgar, a chess champion, for the job, but Ms Polgar declined. With Mr Baka, Hungary will get a dissident of the Orbán regime who has fought for the independence of the judiciary and the rule of law.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which London landmark, designed by Sir George Gilbert Scott, features sculptures representing four continents, and four arts and sciences, as well as of the central figure it is named after?

Monday: Which British political party, founded in 1900, produced prime ministers such as Ramsay MacDonald and Harold Wilson?

True originality consists not in a new manner, but in a new vision.

Edith Wharton